

D675

Elementary Literacy Methods

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

Method © 2026 Erik Daniel Lindquist — Course Mastery Coach, armored drill. Items drafted with AI assistance under his direction.

How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A fifth-grade teacher who runs the school's book fair is preparing a passage about a reluctant inventor whose invention of a telegraph relay proved significant. The passage has 1,200 words and several color photos. Which set of words best fits direct vocabulary instruction?

- A. All 1,200 words, to be safe.
- B. reluctant, significant
- C. inventor, photo
- D. telegraph, relay

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A teacher sorts words from a science text into tiers. Which word is Tier 3?

- A. determine
- B. Any science word is Tier 3.
- C. photosynthesis
- D. leaf

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

In a novel the class is reading during a snowy week, a sixth grader meets this sentence: "Leo was taciturn at the party, but his sister was talkative and chatted with everyone." The book won a regional award. Which type of context clue helps with "taciturn"?

- A. A definition clue — the sentence defines taciturn directly.
- B. An antonym (contrast) clue — "but" shows taciturn is the opposite of talkative.
- C. A synonym clue — taciturn means talkative.
- D. No clue exists, so students must always use a dictionary.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

A fourth-grade teacher who recently earned a reading endorsement is introducing summarizing. Her class of 27 is energetic after lunch. Which plan follows the gradual release of responsibility?

- A. Model summarizing every day for the whole year.
- B. Think aloud while summarizing a short text, summarize the next one together, have partners try one, then have students summarize alone.
- C. Hand out a summarizing worksheet for independent work.
- D. Have students summarize alone first, then model if they struggle.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ___	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
-----------------------------	---	----------------------	----------------------------------

5.

A fifth-grade class reads an article that states, “Because the town cut down the trees along the river, the banks eroded. As a result, the water became muddy and fish populations dropped.” The article is from a children’s magazine with bright illustrations. Which graphic organizer best matches the structure?

- A. A cause-and-effect chain.
- B. A labeled picture web.
- C. A Venn diagram.
- D. A story map with characters and setting.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ___	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
-----------------------------	---	----------------------	----------------------------------

6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A teacher wants students to write a paragraph using problem/solution structure. Which set of signal words should she teach?

- A. “The problem is... one solution... this was solved by...”
- B. “Because... as a result...”
- C. “First... next... finally...”
- D. “Similarly... however... on the other hand...”

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ___	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
-----------------------------	---	----------------------	----------------------------------

7.

A story read in a sixth-grade class with new laptops says: “Maya slammed her locker, stared at the red F on her paper, and did not answer when her friend said hi.” The author also wrote a popular series. Which statement is an inference?

- A. Maya will fail the class and change schools.
- B. Maya got an F on her paper.
- C. Maya is upset about her grade.
- D. Maya prefers the author’s other series.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A fourth grader who reads grade-level stories fluently and is the class’s best speller struggles to understand an article on volcanoes because she knows almost nothing about them. The teacher has a small classroom budget for new materials. What is the best instructional response?

- A. Place her in phonics intervention.
- B. Assign more generic main-idea worksheets on random topics.
- C. Spend the budget on spelling games.
- D. Build knowledge with a set of connected texts, images, and discussion about volcanoes before and during the article.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A fifth grader with dyslexia, who is a strong swimmer, decodes at about a second-grade level but understands grade-level science when it is read aloud. His teacher has a co-teacher two days a week. Which support is an intervention rather than an accommodation?

- A. Audiobooks of the science textbook.
- B. Having the co-teacher read all texts to him all year instead of reading instruction.
- C. Extra time on tests.
- D. Daily explicit, systematic instruction in decoding multisyllable words.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A student with dyslexia is receiving daily decoding intervention. Which support gives her access to grade-level social studies content now?

- A.** Text-to-speech for the social studies readings.
- B.** Nothing until her decoding reaches grade level.
- C.** Easier social studies standards.
- D.** More decoding lessons during social studies.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

At a fall data meeting in a school with a new principal, universal screening shows that 12 of 28 fourth graders in one class meet the reading benchmark. The class moved to a new wing this year. What is the best MTSS decision?

- A.** Wait until the class settles into the new wing.
- B.** Refer them to Tier 3 because the scores are so low.
- C.** Refer all 16 students below benchmark to Tier 2.
- D.** Strengthen Tier 1 core instruction for the whole class, since about 43% meeting benchmark signals a core problem.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A school expects at least 80% of students to meet benchmark when core instruction is working. In a class of 25, what is the minimum number who should meet benchmark?

- A.** 25
- B.** 80
- C.** 20
- D.** 5

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer B Concept 1

A fifth-grade teacher ~~who runs the school's book fair~~ is preparing a passage about a reluctant inventor whose invention of a telegraph relay proved significant. ~~The passage has 1,200 words and several color photos.~~ Which set of words best fits direct vocabulary instruction?

Target word: which words to teach **Decides:** Tier 2 words are useful across many texts.

A	Wrong stem number	Uses the word count; teaching every word is neither possible nor useful.
B	Correct	General academic words students will meet across subjects — the best return on teaching time.
C	Confusion set	Tier 1 everyday words most fifth graders already know.
D	Adjacent category	Tier 3, topic-specific terms; explain them briefly in context.

2. Answer C Concept 1 • transfer

A teacher sorts words from a science text into tiers. Which word is Tier 3?

Target word: identify Tier 3 — reverse of choosing Tier 2 **Decides:** Tier 3 = domain-specific, low-frequency.

A	Inverted operation	A Tier 2 academic word used across subjects.
B	Absolute language	Science texts contain words from all three tiers.
C	Correct	Specific to one field and rare in general reading.
D	Confusion set	Tier 1 everyday word.

3. Answer B Concept 2

In a novel the class is reading ~~during a snowy week~~, a sixth grader meets this sentence: “Leo was taciturn at the party, but his sister was talkative and chatted with everyone.” ~~The book won a regional award.~~ Which type of context clue helps with “taciturn”?

Target word: type of context clue **Decides:** “But” sets Leo against a talkative sister — a contrast clue.

A	Adjacent category	No phrase like “which means” or an appositive defines the word.
B	Correct	The signal word “but” contrasts Leo with his talkative sister, so taciturn means quiet.
C	Inverted operation	Reads the contrast as a match; “but” signals the opposite.
D	Absolute language	The sentence contains a clear contrast clue.

4. Answer B Concept 3

A fourth-grade teacher ~~who recently earned a reading endorsement~~ is introducing summarizing. ~~Her class of 27 is energetic after lunch.~~ Which plan follows the gradual release of responsibility?

Target word: order of strategy instruction **Decides:** Model, guide, collaborate, then independent.

A	Absolute language	Never releases responsibility to students.
B	Correct	I do, we do, you do together, you do alone.
C	Dropped element	Drops modeling and guided practice.
D	Inverted operation	Reverses the release.

5. Answer A Concept 4

A fifth-grade class reads an article that states, “Because the town cut down the trees along the river, the banks eroded. As a result, the water became muddy and fish populations dropped.” The article is ~~from a children’s magazine with bright illustrations~~. Which graphic organizer best matches the structure?

Target word: organizer for the text structure **Decides:** “Because” and “as a result” signal cause/effect.

A	Correct	Each event causes the next; signal words confirm it.
B	Camouflage	Keys on the illustrations; description webs miss the causal chain.
C	Confusion set	Fits compare/contrast.
D	Adjacent category	A narrative tool; this is informational text.

6. Answer A Concept 4 • transfer

A teacher wants students to write a paragraph using problem/solution structure. Which set of signal words should she teach?

Target word: signal words for a given structure — reverse of identifying it **Decides:** Problem/solution language.

A	Correct	Names a problem and the response.
B	Inverted operation	Cause/effect signals — close, but explains why, not how it was fixed.
C	Confusion set	Sequence signals.
D	Adjacent category	Compare/contrast signals.

7. Answer C Concept 5

A story read in a sixth-grade class ~~with new laptops~~ says: “Maya slammed her locker, stared at the red F on her paper, and did not answer when her friend said hi.” ~~The author also wrote a popular series.~~ Which statement is an inference?

Target word: a valid inference **Decides:** Text clues + background knowledge → an unstated idea.

A	Absolute language	Goes beyond the evidence — a guess, not an inference.
B	Adjacent category	Stated in the text — a literal detail, not an inference.
C	Correct	Slamming, staring at the F, and ignoring her friend plus what readers know about disappointment support it.
D	Camouflage	Uses the author detail; nothing in the text supports it.

8. Answer D Concept 6

A fourth grader who reads grade-level stories fluently ~~and is the class’s best speller~~ struggles to understand an article on volcanoes because she knows almost nothing about them. ~~The teacher has a small classroom budget for new materials.~~ What is the best instructional response?

Target word: respond to a knowledge gap **Decides:** Comprehension depends on topic knowledge.

A	Confusion set	Her decoding is strong.
B	Dropped element	Drops the knowledge factor; skills do not supply missing content.
C	Camouflage	Uses the budget and spelling details; irrelevant to comprehension.
D	Correct	Background knowledge is a major driver of comprehension.

9. Answer D Concept 7

A fifth grader with dyslexia, ~~who is a strong swimmer~~, decodes at about a second-grade level but understands grade-level science when it is read aloud. ~~His teacher has a co-teacher two days a week~~. Which support is an intervention rather than an accommodation?

Target word: identify the intervention **Decides:** An intervention teaches the missing decoding skill.

A	Confusion set	An accommodation — gives access without teaching decoding.
B	Camouflage	Uses the co-teacher detail; replaces instruction with access.
C	Adjacent category	An accommodation for access, not skill building.
D	Correct	Teaches the skill he lacks.

10. Answer A Concept 7 • transfer

A student with dyslexia is receiving daily decoding intervention. Which support gives her access to grade-level social studies content now?

Target word: choose the accommodation — reverse of choosing the intervention **Decides:** Access without changing the skill taught.

A	Correct	Provides access to content while intervention builds decoding.
B	Dropped element	Drops access to content in the meantime.
C	Adjacent category	That modifies expectations, which is different from an accommodation.
D	Inverted operation	That is intervention and would cost her the content.

11. Answer D Concept 8

At a fall data meeting ~~in a school with a new principal~~, universal screening shows that 12 of 28 fourth graders in one class meet the reading benchmark. ~~The class moved to a new wing this year~~. What is the best MTSS decision?

Target word: respond to screening **Decides:** $12 / 28 \approx 43\%$, far below about 80% — the core needs strengthening.

A	Camouflage	The new wing does not explain the data.
B	Adjacent category	Tier 3 is for a few students not responding to Tier 1 and 2.
C	Wrong stem number	Tier 2 cannot absorb more than half the class; the core is the issue.
D	Correct	When the core is working, about 80% should meet benchmark; far below that, fix the core first.

12. Answer C Concept 8 • transfer

A school expects at least 80% of students to meet benchmark when core instruction is working. In a class of 25, what is the minimum number who should meet benchmark?

Target word: solve for the count from the percent **Decides:** 25×0.80 .

A	Absolute language	Requires every student; the guideline is about 80%.
B	Wrong stem number	The percent, not a count.
C	Correct	$25 \times 0.80 = 20$.
D	Inverted operation	That is the most who may fall below benchmark, not the number meeting it.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	3	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	3	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	8	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	6	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	5	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	6	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	5	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Tier 2 vocabulary	Direct vocabulary teaching pays off most on Tier 2 words — general academic words that appear across many texts and subjects (analyze, reluctant, significant).	Spending instruction on everyday Tier 1 words or rare Tier 3 terms.	“Which words from this passage should be taught directly?”
2	Types of context clues	Context clues come as definition, synonym, antonym (contrast), example, and inference (general sense); signal words mark the type.	Mislabeling a contrast clue (“unlike,” “but”) as a synonym.	A sentence with a signal word near an unfamiliar word.
3	Gradual release of responsibility	Comprehension strategies are taught I do (model with think-aloud), we do (guided), you do together, then you do alone.	Assigning a strategy worksheet with no modeling, or modeling forever.	A teacher introducing a new strategy such as summarizing.
4	Informational text structure	Recognizing structure — description, sequence, compare/contrast, cause/effect, problem/solution — guides comprehension; signal words and graphic organizers match the structure.	Choosing an organizer that does not match the text’s structure.	Signal words like “because,” “as a result,” “however,” “similarly.”
5	Making inferences	An inference combines clues in the text with the reader’s background knowledge to reach an idea the text does not state.	Accepting a literal detail or an unsupported guess as an inference.	“What can the reader infer...?”
6	Knowledge building drives comprehension	Background knowledge strongly predicts comprehension; build it through connected text sets and topic study, not generic skills practice alone.	Assuming comprehension is a set of skills that transfer to any topic.	A student who reads fluently but cannot follow an unfamiliar topic.
7	Accommodation vs. intervention for dyslexia	An accommodation gives access without changing the skill taught (audiobook, extended time); an intervention teaches the missing skill (explicit decoding instruction). Upper-grade students with dyslexia usually need both.	Using an accommodation as if it fixed the skill gap.	“Which support teaches the skill?” vs. “Which gives access to grade-level content?”

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
8	Tier 1 core instruction in MTSS	Tier 1 is high-quality core instruction for all; when fewer than about 80% of students meet benchmark on universal screening, strengthen the core rather than send most students to Tier 2.	Referring half the class to intervention instead of fixing core instruction.	Screening results showing many students below benchmark.

Course scope (public description): Elementary Literacy Methods is an engaging and comprehensive course designed for aspiring educators, focusing on the development of effective literacy teaching strategies for elementary-level students. This course reviews the fundamental principles of literacy education through science of reading, but takes a more specialized focus on vocabulary development, reading comprehension, and the deeply complex literacy skills developed in grades 4 to 6. Candidates explore a variety of instructional approaches and materials tailored to support all learners in the elementary classroom, including learners with dyslexia. This exposure will assist candidates in using Tier 1 multi-tiered systems of support and assessment (MTSS) for planning and implementing literacy lessons, selecting appropriate resources, and assessing student progress.